

Student Affairs in an Increasingly Multicultural World

This chapter looks at student affairs in an increasingly multicultural world. From previous class discussions, we have learned that student affairs professionals have a wide range of functional areas and possess both breadth and depth of knowledge across competency areas, including working with people, skills, theories, organizational structures, legal, strategic planning, budgeting, and institutional. This chapter echoes a theme mentioned in earlier chapters: a student affairs administrator (SAA) is not only a professional but also a leader, educator, and manager. In today's ever-changing society, they must be aware of an increasingly multicultural and increasingly diverse society. Multicultural competency is essential knowledge and skills for becoming a successful SSA or any leader.

This chapter presents four perspectives on multiculturalism: drivers of diversity, challenges and opportunities for SAAs, the equity-sensitive perspective (ESP), and programs and strategies. The first concerns demographic changes in the American higher education system. The second is how to deal with the emerging population and address the issue it poses. The ESP is a model for managing change. Lastly, it's about multicultural competency. All these perspectives provide SAA with awareness of the changes taking place in our society and institutions, as our population is very diverse and growing rapidly. At the same time, SAA must be multicultural sensitive to differences in racial, ethnic, and cultural diversity. This is essential knowledge and skills, and it comes with a responsibility as an SAA. That is why SAA must accept change and must be a believer that change is evolving and good. Just like a leader is truly a believer and committed to diversity in the institutional mission statement. This synopsis primarily focuses on the ESP, programs, and strategies.

The ESP section starts by defining the role of the student affairs administrator, which leads into a synergistic change management model for managing change. This model provides a framework for monitoring or evaluating an activity's effect or goal attainment. It's managing and changing. It's an integrated model that focuses on people, processes, and programs. This model shows that institutional processes and programs need to be designed to serve all people, regardless of their own racial, ethnic, or cultural background.

Why is ESP so important to SAA? The role of SAA is "leader, educator, and manager is an interdependent set that is greater and more effective than the sum of its parts (pg. 70). It's saying the role of leader, educator, and manager by itself is less effective than the combined functions. That is the same as saying that when people truly work as a team, they can produce breakthrough results. Another interpretation of this meaning is that when people respect and embrace ethnic and cultural diversity, they can live in harmony with each other.

Multicultural competency is defined as "

"Awareness, knowledge, and skills that are needed to interact effectively with others who are culturally different (pg. 75).

Multicultural skills are defined as:

"Capabilities, behaviors, and practices that enable individuals to interact effectively and meaningfully with others whose backgrounds are different from their own" (pg. 75).

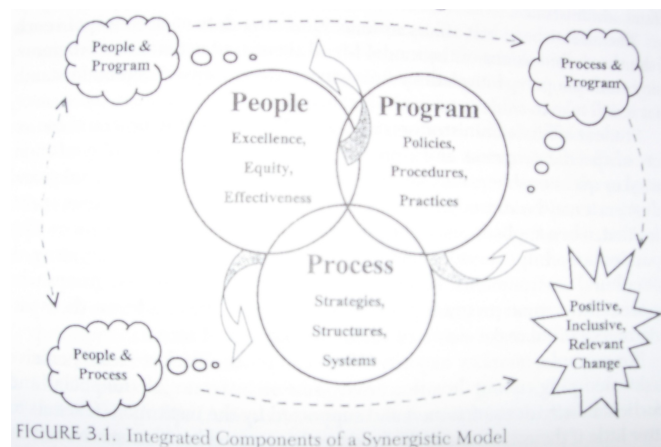
Multicultural Competent (pg. 75)

- One must have pride within one's own cultural group
- No one group is better than another
- Discrimination because one's cultural status is unjust
- Assumptions about an individual cannot be based solely on one's group membership
- One must take risks in life
- Cross-cultural interactions enhance the quality of one's life

Gurin's (1999) conceptual model of the impact of diversity (pg. 76):

- Structural diversity – primarily the racial/ethnic composition of the student body
- Classroom diversity – the incorporation of knowledge about the diverse group
- Informal interaction diversity – the opportunity to interact with students from diverse backgrounds in the broad campus environment.

ESP Model (pg. 71)



Application of ESP Model (pg. 73)

<u>People=</u>	Leading/Educating		
	<u>Excellence</u> Values/Beliefs Assumptions, Desires/Needs	<u>Equity</u> Diversity, Access Fairness	<u>Effectiveness</u> Relevant, Performance-based, Positive Results
<u>Process=</u>	Managing		
	<u>Structures</u> Organizational arrangements	<u>Systems</u> Resource Delivery mechanisms	<u>Strategies</u> Short & long term plans
<u>Program=</u>	Educating/Leading		
	<u>Policies</u> Direction, Responsibility, Accountability	<u>Practices</u> Individual & Organizational Behaviors	<u>Procedures</u> Expectations Standards, Guidance

FIGURE 3.2. Application of ESP Model: Student Affairs Administrator Role

Conclusion

I think that this chapter is very important for educating the future SAA. America's population demographics are growing and changing. Our way of life, schools, economy, values, and beliefs are being tested to see whether we are embracing a worldview of ethnic and cultural diversity in which all people are treated the same way and deserve the same opportunities as everyone else. This is an American challenge. The topics presented in this chapter are very good for helping us confront these diversities, especially at the institutional level. SAA needs to acknowledge ethnic and cultural diversity at its institution. Their policies and practices must change to fit the needs of all students. The book provides compelling reasons for diversity. I think one of the many reasons we are advancing so rapidly in technology is that we understand the importance of diversity. Can our policies and practices change to confront social injustice and unfairness head-on?